

Stress Management Lesson Plan

Facilitator Guide | Interactive Class Format | Glenn Morgan

OPENING PRAYER

Father God,

We thank You for bringing us together today. In a world that feels loud and fast, help us to slow down for a moment and breathe in Your peace.

Teach us to handle stress not with fear, but with faith. Remind us that we do not have to carry every burden on our own, because You promised to carry them with us.

As we laugh, learn, and even get a little uncomfortable today, let it all lead us closer to Your calm and steady presence.

Bless this time, bless each person here, and fill this room with focus, joy, and peace that passes understanding.

In Jesus' name we pray, Amen.

1. START THE DISCUSSION

WRITE ON BOARD: Stress

Ask the group: What is stress?

Take answers from the room. Keep it conversational and interactive.

2. THE THREE TYPES OF STRESS

WRITE ON BOARD: What are the 3 types of stress?

- **Physical stress** - Ask: Define physical stress for me.
- **Emotional stress** - Ask: Define emotional stress for me.
- **Cognitive stress** - Cognitive stress refers to the mental strain and pressure caused by our thoughts, perceptions, and beliefs. It is a type of stress that arises from within our minds, rather than from external factors such as physical or social stressors.

3. THE STRESS CYCLE

WRITE ON BOARD: Trigger, Thought, Feeling, Reaction, Result

Give examples of each:

- **Trigger:** Someone puts you on the spot in front of a group.
- **Thought:** I am going to mess this up.
- **Feeling:** Anxiety, embarrassment, frustration.
- **Reaction:** Shut down, joke, get irritated, rush, avoid.
- **Result:** Mistakes, tension, conflict, regret, more stress.

Explain reaction types: Fight, Flight, Freeze

- **Fight:** Push back, argue, get defensive, get angry.
- **Flight:** Avoid, withdraw, escape, leave mentally or physically.
- **Freeze:** Blank mind, stuck, unable to respond, shut down.

4. ACTIVITY 1 | CONTROLLED STRESS DEMO

Set Up

- Pick someone you are friends with.
- Ask: Are we friends?
- Ask: Do you feel safe?
- Ask: Do you typically see stress coming and deal with it well?
- Tell them: Stand up and stand next to me.

Directions

You have 30 seconds to count to 30. Ready?

Wait. When I say go, everyone count down from 30 together.

Ready?

Pretend to start.

Oh, I forgot one last part. Skip all numbers that have the letter E in it. Go.

Debrief

WRITE ON BOARD: Physical | Emotional | Cognitive

Ask: Tell me how you felt.

Pull out physical, emotional, and cognitive responses from the volunteer and the group.

5. ACTIVITY 2 | FOLLOW DIRECTIONS

Use the handout and audience instructions you already prepared.

After the activity ask: Tell me how you felt.

Again, sort the answers under **physical**, **emotional**, and **cognitive**.

6. DISAPPOINTMENT AND STRESS

Disappointment causes stress.

Disappointment is the delta between expectation and reality.

Ask: Which can you control?

7. HOW DO YOU HANDLE STRESS?

WRITE ON BOARD: 4 P's

- **Pause** - Stop before reacting.
- **Be Present** - Come back to what is actually happening right now.
- **Be Patient** - Slow down, do not force the moment.
- **Pray** - Bring it to God before you carry it alone.

8. HEALTHY COPING SKILLS

1. Micro meditation combined with deep breathing
2. Body scan from head to toes
3. Short walk or movement break
4. Prayer and scripture reading
5. Journaling what you can control
6. Talking to a trusted person
7. Hydrate, eat, and rest
8. Worship music or calming music

9. UNHEALTHY COPING SKILLS

- Avoidance
- Isolation
- Anger and lashing out
- Shutting down
- Overeating or not eating
- Substance use
- Doom scrolling and screen numbing
- Blaming others for everything
- Pretending you are fine when you are not
- Making impulsive decisions under pressure

10. SCRIPTURE TIE-IN

“Faith Without Works is Dead”

“What good is it, my brothers, if someone says he has faith but does not have works? Can that faith save him? If a brother or sister is poorly clothed and lacking in daily food, and one of you says to them, “Go in peace, be warmed and filled,” without giving them the things needed for the body, what good is that? So also faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead.”

“But someone will say, “You have faith and I have works.” Show me your faith apart from your works, and I will show you my faith by my works.”

James 2:14-18, ESV

Teaching point: Knowing healthy stress tools is not enough. We have to practice them. Faith, wisdom, and coping skills all become real when they are lived out.

11. CLOSING LINE

Stress is real, but it does not have to run your life. Notice it, name it, slow down, and choose your response. Do not just learn the tools, use the tools.